

DECISIVE MOMENT August 13, 1961 Early morning

Berlin Wall

The peace of a Sunday morning in 1961 was shattered as Berliners woke up to the sounds of military vehicles unloading coils of barbed wire and concrete posts in the streets. In central Potsdamer Platz, men used pneumatic drills to break up the cobblestones and set up concrete pillars. These disturbing scenes were the first signs of a physical division of Berlin.

In February 1945, the leaders of the US, USSR, and Britain met in Yalta (now in Ukraine but once part of the Soviet Union) to plan Europe's future after the defeat of Nazi Germany. They agreed to partition Germany and its capital, Berlin, into four zones of occupation divided between their three countries and France. Berlin lay deep inside the Soviet zone, but access between the western zones of the city and the three western zones of Germany was guaranteed along specified land and air links.

The agreement fell apart as the Cold War (see pp. 406–07) gained pace in 1946–47. The election of an anti-communist mayor for Berlin in early 1948 and the planned creation of a federal state with a common currency in the western zones of Germany annoyed the Soviets. On June 24, 1948, they blocked traffic from entering the city from the west. The British and Americans responded with a massive airlift of supplies to sustain West Berlin until an agreement with the Soviets was reached in May 1949.

For the next 12 years, Berlin remained the uneasy epicenter of the Cold War. The western half became

linked with West Germany, while the eastern half became the capital of communist East Germany, both created in 1949. Economic disparities between west and east led thousands of East Germans and Berliners—almost 200,000 in 1960 alone—to cross the open frontier between east and west in search of a better life.

In 1961 the East German government decided to act. Crossing points between East and West Berlin were sealed off with barbed wire and concrete posts. In places, this barrier ran down the middle of streets to keep from touching West Berlin's soil. It even bisected a cemetery. The border between East and West Germany was sealed. Russian tanks waited outside the city, while the Americans sent 1,500 troops to reassure West Berlin.

Over the next 19 years, the wall was strengthened with reinforced concrete blocks 12 ft (3.6 m) high and set back from the original fence to create a heavily armed “no-man's land” in between. The wall became the symbol of a divided world, but ultimately symbolized the futility of such confrontation. Its fall on November 9, 1989, ended the Cold War.

A city divided

Many families were split up when the wall was built. This photo, taken in 1962, shows a young woman standing precariously at the top of the western side of the wall to speak to her mother in East Berlin. About 5,000 people escaped from the east through gaps in the wall.

“You cannot be **held in slavery** forever.”

WILLY BRANDT, MAYOR OF WEST BERLIN, BROADCAST, AUGUST 1961

